ruling coalition. An indication of this internecine war came during the state legislative council elections—which, incidentally, the Mahayuti swept—where the cross-voting and shock defeat of a Shiv Sena candidate revealed the deep fissures within. The electoral college for the legislative council elections consists of corporators, members of zilla parishads and chairpersons of panchayat samitis.

Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray wryly noted that the defection of his six MPs was not 'Operation Tiger', as Shinde and his men claimed, but 'Operation Devendra' orchestrated by Union home minister Amit Shah to nip chief minister Fadnavis's prime ministerial aspirations in the bud. Uddhav has good reason to be peeved: this is the third major split in his party since June 2022. Fadnavis, meanwhile, was quick with the denial, adding it was enough that he had the "blessings of the 140 million people of Maharashtra and the senior leaders of his party".

Takeaways

- **The rise in Shiv Sena's numbers have led to some unease in the BJP, the dominant Mahayuti ally**
- **Legislative council polls see cross-voting in many seats, takes sheen off big alliance win**
- **Opposition MVA in complete disarray, lets ruling alliance win 6 seats unopposed**

INNER RUMBLINGS

The Mahayuti may have swept the legislative council elections, but all the drama was happening in Nashik where Narendra Darade of the Shinde-led Sena saw a shock defeat at the hands of BJP rebel Gokul Gite. Gite had entered the fray against Darade as an independent, but was ready to stand down after intervention from ministers Girish Mahajan (BJP) and Uday Samant (Shiv Sena). However, since the deadline for withdrawals had passed, his name remained on the ballot paper. Darade was expecting a cakewalk, but Gite continued to galvanise support on the ground, allegedly with support from the BJP leadership. He is also said to have pulled votes from the MVA. After the loss, Darade was left fuming, but things were smoothed out between the ruling allies after the BJP allegedly 'allowed' Gite to become an associate member of the Sena.

Meanwhile, cross-voting also robbed some of the sheen of the victory for the BJP in Satara-Sangli (where the NCP-SP managed to split around 100 Mahayuti votes), Solapur and Bhandara-Gondia. "This was a one-sided affair," says political analyst Abhay Deshpande. "The Mahayuti constituents have exterminated their political opponents, so they are now turning on each other."

The 'extermination' fear is real in the MVA. Things were so bad that the Sena (UBT) and the Congress saw nominees withdrawing from the fray in seats like Raigad-Ratnagiri-Sindhudurg and Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar (Aurangabad). In the end, Mahayuti candidates were elected unopposed in six of the 17 seats up for election. ■

RAJASTHAN

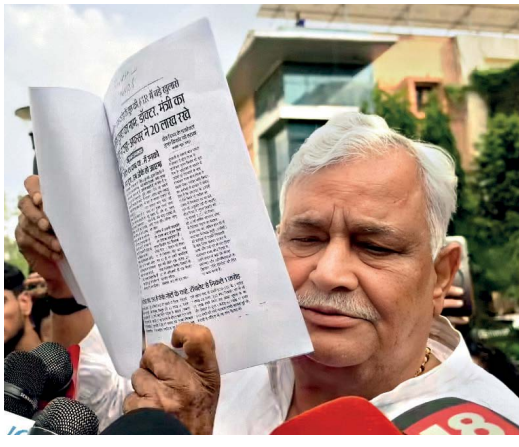
Kirori Kicks up a Storm

The agriculture minister and agent provocateur has put the party on the spot again, this time with reason

By **Rohit Parihar**

THE BHARATIYA JANATA PARTY (BJP) HAS FINALLY pressed the reset button in Rajasthan. After close to two and a half years, it has filled the key post of state organisational general secretary by appointing Ajaey Kumar, a move seen as a precursor to the long-pending panchayat and urban local body elections. Yet, even as so much is going on, the party finds itself grappling with a political challenge from within. Agriculture minister Kirori Lal Meena, a constant bugbear for the state government, is again in the news after turning what began as an anti-corruption bureau (ACB) investigation into a wider confrontation involving the Opposition Congress, the ACB and, increasingly, his own party.

The controversy erupted after the



WHICH 'DOCTOR' Kirori Lal Meena waves the maligning media reports